

Licensing Effect

What is it?

After doing something good, people feel justified to later do something less good or self-indulgent.

History

Discussed in behavioral psychology research since around **2009**, where studies showed that people felt more freedom to act against their goals after completing a positive action first.

The Psychology Behind It

- A good action creates a psychological sense of “credit”
- People believe they’ve earned a reward or excuse
- Leads to contradictory choices even if they go against long-term goals
- Seen across health, productivity, sustainability, spending, and self-control behaviors

Why It Matters

- Sudden drop-off after good actions
- Harder to maintain consistent behavior
- Reduced long-term follow-through
- Lower goal achievement overall

How to Apply It

- Reinforce forward momentum (progress bars, streaks, points)
- Suggest next good step instead of delivering instant reward
- Frame journeys as continuous, not one-time achievements
- Delay gratification prompts to avoid early self-rewarding

Theory in Action

- Duolingo uses streak reinforcement to prevent users from mentally “checking out” after progress
- Retail brands use cause-based purchases to justify additional indulgent buying behavior

Final Thought

One good decision doesn’t guarantee another.

Design must guide users toward consistency — not give permission to reverse progress.

